

The tripartite Agricultural Workforce Working Group (the Working Group) met for the third time on 15 December 2022.

Members noted the update on action items being progressed following the 15 November meeting which focused on skills and migration issues affecting the agriculture and processing sectors. Progress has been made on a number of fronts, including:

- the announcement of 13,050 new fee-free TAFE places for agriculture courses across the country;
- the highest ever number of PALM scheme workers in the country, with more than 33,700 workers in Australia right now;
- Working Holiday Maker visa holders are returning with over 105,000 in the country as at 4 December 2022;
- significant progress on the visa backlog with over 3 million visas finalised since 1 June 2022;
- the announcement this week of Skills Impact as the new Jobs and Skills Council for agribusiness.

Members also welcomed today's announcement that the Government will be expanding access to the PALM scheme to metropolitan-based employers in meat, seafood, and fruit and vegetable processing.

Members endorsed a joint submission to the review of Australia's migration system which sets out three agreed principles for migration in Australia's agriculture and processing sectors. These principles are that:

- at this time, Australian agriculture and its processing sectors require a level of migration to support its workforce.
- all workers have the right to be treated fairly at work.
- there are opportunities to improve Australia's migration system to better support agriculture and its processing sectors at the system and visa setting levels.

A migration subgroup of the working group will explore a number of specific suggestions to ensure migration programs and policies meet the needs of agricultural employers and workers.

Members agreed that all workers in agriculture and processing should be treated fairly, including with respect to pay and working conditions. Members agreed to progress further work in the areas of:

- providing advice to Government on preferred models of labour hire regulation and best practice standards;
- building employer and employee workplace relations capability including with respect to worker inductions and pay deductions;
- promoting and strengthening strategies and programs that have been successful in improving workplace standards and worker conditions.

The Working Group will next meet in February 2023.

Attendees

- Senator the Hon. Murray Watt, Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry
- Fiona Simson, President, National Farmers' Federation
- Patrick Hutchinson, CEO, Australian Meat Industry Council
- Matt Journeaux, Federal Secretary, Australasian Meat Industry Employees Union
- Jannette Armstrong, Executive Director - Farms, United Workers Union
- Ann Gardiner, National Council member, Australian Dairy Farmers
- Richard Shannon, Executive Officer, NFF Horticulture Council
- Scott Connolly, Assistant Secretary, The Australian Council of Trade Unions
- Shane Roulstone, National Organising Director, Australian Workers' Union
- Tony Mahar, CEO, National Farmers' Federation
- Andrew Metcalfe AO, Secretary, Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry
- James Flintoft, Independent Facilitator
- John Azarias, Special Advisor to the Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry on Agricultural Workforce Issues.

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/about/news/stay-informed/communiques/ag-workforce-working-group-december-2022>